

before a knowledgeable person told me that over-the-counter headquarters was located in Washington. Later, I learned that "over-the-counter" is the popular name for the National Association of Securities Dealers Automated Quotations, or NASDAQ.

Shunning the expensive Metroliner, I took the slow train down to Washington, then shared a cab into town. The cab let me off in front of a small office building on K Street, which at first I thought was a mistaken address. After seeing the great marble facade of the New York Stock Exchange, I was not prepared for NASDAQ to look like the National Asphalt Council, or any similar run-of-the-mill Washington organization.

Inside the NASDAQ building, there was no checkpoint, no guard, and hardly a lobby—just an empty hallway and a couple of elevators. I took one of these up to the public relations office. There I was met by Enno Hobbing, vice-president of the news department, with whom I'd made an appointment.

Mr. Hobbing was wearing a rumpled seersucker suit, and looked considerably more relaxed than anybody I'd seen in the dining room of the NYSE. As he threaded me through the usual secretarial cubicles, around the file drawers, past the Xerox machine, he told me about his earlier career as an editor for the old *Life* magazine.

Inside his office, Mr. Hobbing described how NASDAQ was catching up to the other exchanges, how the institutional investors were buying more over-the-counter stocks, and how NASDAQ had grown to 4,000 companies, more than twice the number represented by the rival NYSE. He said that NASDAQ stocks were worth a collective \$360 billion on the day of my visit. The largest of the companies traded on NASDAQ were included in what Mr. Hobbing called the National Market System. It provided up-to-the-minute transaction reports just as the NYSE did. There was a second tier of less-important stocks, simply called over-the-counter, and finally a third tier of the smallest and least-important issues, called the supplementals. Angstrom, I knew, was one of those.

"Does supplemental mean something's wrong?" I asked.

"Not really," Mr. Hobbing said. "Supplementals are small stocks, not widely followed. These are companies that don't meet the financial requirements to make our other lists, but that doesn't